



"We believe medical professionals are instruments in God's health ministry."

KIM MAMMEN,
DEPUTY DIRECTOR, CMC, LUDHIANA

leaving Ida wishing she could have done more. Soon she graduated in the first class of women medical students from Cornell University, coming back to India to set up a dispensary by the name of Mary Taber Schell in 1902, which is now known as CMC, Vellore. It is known for its many achievements—the country's first heart valve replacement (1961), the first kidney transplant (1971) and the first trans-catheter carotid stenting in the world in 1996. It was one of the first Asian hospitals to have been certified by ISO. India's first stem cell translational research centre was set up here in 2005. It proudly claims to a rehabilitation centre for the physically-disabled, with a leprosy research institute, rural healthcare section and a renowned virology research department.

by Ramesh Vinayak and Stephen David

TO SERVE AND CARE

"My work is for a King" was the abiding motto of Edith Mary Brown, and by King she meant The Almighty. She was conferred the Order of the British Empire in 1932 by George V. In 1912, she was awarded the 'Kaiser-e-Hind' Silver Medal by the provincial government of Punjab.

SANKARA NETHRALAYA, CHENNAI

THE EYES HAVE IT

There's an inevitable buzz when there are over 1,500 people under one roof. A sadhu with his prayer beads walks past an old woman admonishing her husband for losing his eye prescription. This is Sankara Nethralaya (SN), one of India's premier temples for eye care, which was born out of a missionary spirit to bring people quality eye care. According to president and founder, Dr S.S. Badrinath, in keeping with its aim to serve all, one-third of all surgeries are free for patients from low-income groups. SN is a non-profit organisation and is supported financially by internal cash generation from patients who pay and donations from philanthropists who believe in the work the institution is doing and wish to be part of it. A lot of emphasis is put on education, training and research in nanotechnology, stem cell, gene typing, glaucoma and diabetic retinopathy. A daily bus heads for the villages around Chennai as part of the Jaslok Community Ophthalmic Centre. It brings back patients for check-ups, treats them and performs cataract surgeries free of cost. For those in remote areas, buses with hi-tech equipment travel through Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Karnataka meeting patients. A successful endeavour, says Dr K.S. Vasan, managing director, soon to be replicated in West Bengal. For Badrinath, success lies in "the look on a patient's face, which can't be replaced by money."

by Chitra Subramanyam



EYE POWER

There are between 8,000 and 9,000 surgeries performed in a year by the Sankara Nethralaya community hospital.